



OpenPantry

Administrator Handbook

FOR ADMINISTRATORS

Setup, configuration, security, reporting, and day-to-day operation of OpenPantry.

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OVERVIEW

About OpenPantry

OpenPantry is a self-contained PHP + SQLite application that helps a food pantry check items out the door, keep a live inventory, and forecast what to reorder — with no database server, build step, or external dependencies to install. It is a hybrid Just-In-Time inventory system built for smaller pantries with limited storage and high-demand essentials.

Every outbound channel — grocery-style barcode checkout, the Menu Counter ordering kiosk, home deliveries, community events, and OrderAhead imports — feeds one inventory and one demand model, so the reorder report always sees the whole picture. This handbook is your reference for standing the system up, keeping it secure, and running it day to day.

WHAT YOU'RE RESPONSIBLE FOR

As administrator you own the four things volunteers never touch: the **OpenAI key & settings**, the **network / hours access gate**, the **admin password & encryption key backup**, and the **reorder cron job**. Each has its own section below.

GETTING INSTALLED

Requirements & deployment

- Any web host with **PHP 8+** and the **pdo_sqlite** extension (standard on every default install).
 - For field encryption, the PHP **sodium** extension (built in on PHP 7.2+).
 - The application folder (and **menucounter/**) must be **writable** by the web server so the databases and encryption key can be created on first hit.
- 1 Copy the whole OpenPantry folder to your host. The nested Menu Counter app ships inside it — no separate deploy.
 - 2 Browse to the app root. The schema builds itself, the produce table seeds, and **openpantry.db** plus **menucounter/picklist.db** are created automatically.
 - 3 Open **Settings** and complete first-time configuration (next section).

DO THIS BEFORE OPENING

First-time configuration (Settings)

Everything below lives on the **Settings** page:

- **Administrator password** — change it from the default **admin** immediately. It is stored one-way hashed and can't be recovered, only reset. Changing it later requires entering the **current password** first, so a walk-up at an unattended screen (or a stolen login cookie) can't silently swap it and lock everyone out.

- **Supervisor password** (optional) — a second login for whoever opens the pantry. It reaches every screen the administrator password does, except that on **Settings** it can only change the **Public IPv4 Address** — the rest of the page is read-only. That lets a shift lead re-point the network gate when the pantry's address changes without being handed the OpenAI key, the mail settings, or the passwords. Setting or removing it asks for the administrator password. Leave it unset and the role doesn't exist — there is no default supervisor password.
- **OpenAI API key** — powers automatic brand→generic naming on new barcodes. Use the **test** button to confirm it works. Stored encrypted at rest. The **Model** field takes any OpenAI chat model; newer reasoning models (gpt-5 and later, the o-series) work too, because OpenPantry adjusts its request to the model family and turns reasoning off or down so first-time scans stay fast.
- **Secure Network Access** — set the **Public IPv4 Address** to your pantry's public Wi-Fi address so the kiosks only work on-site. Up to **two additional addresses** can be allowed as well — a backup internet line, or a second site. Leave them all blank during setup to avoid locking yourself out, then set them. A supervisor can change the primary address; the two additional ones are administrator-only.
- **Allowed hours** — optional weekly schedule that closes the kiosks outside service times.
- **Administrator email** — where reorder-reminder digests are sent — and where login soft-lock codes go (next section), so keep it current.
- **Email notifications (SMTP)** — optional authenticated sending; otherwise the app uses PHP `mail()`. Use **Send Test Email** to verify delivery.
- **Produce tare** — ounces subtracted from hand-typed produce weights (not scale readings).
- **USB scale pairing** — a HID Point-of-Sale scale (the kind USPS postage software uses, e.g. the DYMO M25) plugs straight into the station with no adapter or driver. Open the scanning page in Chrome or Edge, click **Connect Scale** once and pick the device; the browser remembers the grant, so every later visit reconnects on its own. Do this once per station and per browser profile — there is no app setting for it. A station still using the older cable-connected scale needs none of this: it types weights in as a keyboard would, and the scale strip described in the Volunteer Handbook never appears.
- **Par-level defaults** — default lead time and safety-stock Z used by the Order Now report, plus **Max Storage (cu ft)**: the report totals the cubic feet an order needs (from each item's Cu Ft/Case on the Inventory page) and warns when it goes over. 0 turns the check off.
- **Ignore Unknown Items** — off, a barcode nobody can name stops the line with the *Identify this item* window. On, the station records it under the placeholder name **Unidentified** and moves on — useful for donated goods you never reorder. The volume still counts in orders and reports, but **Unidentified** never drives a reorder. Turn it back off and the next scan of each such barcode asks for a name, which also renames that barcode's past scans.
- **Food pantry name & logo** — branding shown in the header and on printed sheets.

PROTECT THIS ABOVE ALL

Security & data privacy

- **Admin password** is stored as a one-way hash (`password_hash`); even the running app can't read it back. The login cookie is derived from the hash, so changing the password instantly logs everyone out.
- **Supervisor password**, when set, is hashed and cookie-bound exactly like the admin one, and the cookie records which of the two opened the session — so a supervisor session stays a supervisor session, and changing or removing that password signs out everyone holding it.
- **Login rate limiting** throttles failed admin logins per IP: two free retries, then 10- and 30-second waits; at the fifth failure the login **soft-locks** and a single-use 6-digit code is emailed to the administrator address (with an escalating 1–10 minute timeout as the fallback when no code can be sent). A successful login clears the slate. Covers both the OpenPantry login and the Menu Counter item admin.
- **Network + hours gate** (in `auth.php`) blocks any device that isn't on one of the allowed IPs or is outside allowed hours, with a styled “Access Denied” wall. A scanning station that is already open when the gate starts refusing it gets a **The server refused this station** window instead, naming which gate it hit. The gate covers the requests behind each page as well as the page itself — the order form's submit, the pick queue's ticks and cancels — so knowing a URL is no way around it.
- **Encryption at rest** (libsodium) now covers **every Settings value** — the OpenAI key, allowed IP, SMTP credentials, and the rest (only the already-hashed admin and supervisor passwords stay hashes) — plus delivery clients' address / city / phone. Existing plaintext rows are upgraded automatically on the next load.

KEEP THE DATABASES OFF THE WEB

The root `.htaccess` refuses to serve `*.db`, `*.db-wal`, `*.db-shm`, and `*.sqlite` files over HTTP, so the databases can't be downloaded by URL even on a default install. For defense in depth, point the `OPENPANTRY_DB_DIR` SetEnv (in `.htaccess`, alongside `OPENPANTRY_KEY_PATH`) at a directory **outside public_html** — both databases are stored there, and an existing in-webroot database is checkpointed and moved across automatically on the next request. The SetEnv values are also honored on CLI runs, so the cron mailer resolves the same files.

THREE TIERS OF ACCESS — AND WHY VOLUNTEERS DON'T LOG IN

The **volunteer kiosks are gated by the allowed IP only**: the scanning stations, the Menu Counter order form and pick queue, and the delivery kiosk open straight to the work screen on the pantry network, with **no password**. The **admin password guards the administrative screens** — the dashboard, Settings, Inventory, Restock, Lookup Tables, Reports, the Menu Counter item admin, and the delivery client roster. The optional **supervisor password** sits between the two: the same administrative screens, but Settings is read-only apart from the IP address controls. Setting the allowed IP correctly is therefore what keeps the kiosks safe, so keep it current whenever the pantry's public address changes.

BACK UP ENCRYPTION_KEY.PHP

The 32-byte key in `encryption_key.php` is generated on first use and is the **only** thing that can decrypt your data. If you lose it, all encrypted fields are gone for good. Back it up, keep it out of version control, and ideally relocate it above the web root via the `OPENPANTRY_KEY_PATH` environment variable or a `FS_ENC_KEY_PATH` constant. On PHP without libsodium, encryption silently degrades to plaintext until a sodium-capable PHP runs.

KEEPING COUNTS HONEST

Managing inventory

- **Inventory page** — the canonical current-count list. Create items here and set each one's unit (`each` or `lb`).
- **Restock** — stage counts and submit a batch that *adds* to inventory, flagged purchased vs. donated (drives the Purchased-% column). No order rows are written, so restocks stay out of usage reports.
- **Deliverable flag** — uncheck it to keep an item in inventory but hide it from the Menu Counter order form.
- **Count-per-case** — set how many units a supplier case holds; the Order Now report then shows a Case Request column (order need ÷ case size, rounded up).
- **Order unit & Avg Wt** — for produce the pantry weighs but the vendor sells by the piece (avocados on the scale in `lb`, bought as a 48-count case): set Order Unit to `each` and Avg Wt to the average pounds per piece. Count-per-case is then read in the order unit, the order sheet and email are written in it, and Restock Now converts the delivery back to pounds. Leave Order Unit on “same as stock” for everything else. Without an Avg Wt there is nothing to convert by, so the order falls back to the stock unit. An Avg Wt also adds a piece count to by-weight lines on the delivery sheets (see Home deliveries).
- **Checkout, deliveries, events, OrderAhead** all decrement inventory automatically as orders close or imports run. Closing an order is all-or-nothing: every item comes out of inventory together, or none do and the order stays open.
- **Zeroing stock in bulk** — **Remove Produce Stock** sets every produce count to zero. **Remove Reorder Alerts Stock** does the same for every item listed in the Order Now report's Reorder Alerts card, whether its alert is switched on or off. Both ask to confirm and can't be undone. To check which items that covers first, pick **Reorder Alerts Only** in the type filter above the table.

BARCODES TO GENERIC NAMES

Lookup tables & naming

OpenPantry stores each item by a plain **generic name** (e.g. “Black Beans”) rather than brand, so demand aggregates cleanly. The first time a UPC is scanned, the app looks it up on Open Food Facts and asks OpenAI to reduce it to a 2–4 word generic, then caches the mapping.

- **Produce** — PLU codes (and 12-digit pantry labels starting with 4) map to produce names; the table ships pre-seeded and you can add more.
- **UPC / Generic Cache** — review and edit AI-derived names in place. If it guessed “Beans” when you wanted “Black Beans”, fix it here and future scans use your edit.
- **Add UPC Manually** — for codes Open Food Facts can't resolve: type the UPC, an optional branded name, and the generic name, and the mapping is cached (source [manual](#)) for all future scans of that code.
- **Naming Unidentified barcodes** — a UPC recorded as **Unidentified** (see Ignore Unknown Items) can be named right here in the UPC cache instead of waiting for a volunteer to scan it again. Renaming a UPC also renames that barcode's own past scans; other Unidentified barcodes are left alone.

Product recalls

When a product is recalled, find its UPC in the **UPC / Generic Cache** and tick **Recalled**. From that moment **every** scanning station refuses the item — including ones that were already open — because the check is made on the server, not the page. A volunteer who scans it gets a red, pulsing **Recalled Product** window and a siren, and has to confirm the package is out of the cart before carrying on. Nothing is recorded, so there is nothing to undo.

- The UPC mapping and its scan history are untouched; clear the box to put the item back into service.
- Ticking and clearing **Recalled** is administrator-only. A supervisor sees the box but can't change it.

A RECALL AT THE STATION MEANS STOCK ON YOUR SHELVES

Volunteers are told to tell the administrator on duty whenever the recall window fires. Take that as the cue to pull the rest of the lot from the shelves — the station only catches the packages that reach checkout.

Merging duplicate item names

The generic name *is* the item — there is no id behind it — so the same food can end up stored under two spellings. The AI returns “Green beans” one week and “Green Beans” the next; a produce code says “Squash Zucchini” while a UPC says “Zucchini”; someone retypes a name. Each variant then keeps its own scan history, its own inventory row, and its own reorder alert, which splits demand in half and **biases both par levels low**. The **De-duplicate** tool merges them back together. It is kept off the main menu: open it with the **Consolidate Names** button on **Settings** (administrator only — a supervisor sees it greyed out), or browse to </openpantry/deduplicate/>.

- **Possible Duplicates** — names that match once case, punctuation, word order, and plurals are ignored are grouped for you. Click **keep** on the spelling you want and **merge** on the one to fold

into it.

- **What a merge moves** — every scan (so the demand history recombines), the UPC mappings and produce codes (so future scans land on the kept name), the inventory row (counts and lifetime restock totals are summed; the kept row's unit, case size, and Order Unit settings win), and any reorder alert. The duplicate then no longer exists.
- **Renaming an item outright** — type a name in the **or type a new name** box instead of picking one, and the whole item moves to that spelling everywhere.
- **“No barcode”** in the name table means no UPC or produce code still resolves to that name, so nothing new can be scanned into it. Usually a leftover from a rename — a good merge candidate. An **Orphan row** has no scans and no codes at all — just an inventory row or reorder alert no other page can reach — and can be **deleted** outright. Anything with scan history has to be merged instead.

A MERGE REWRITES HISTORY AND CANNOT BE UNDONE

Merging edits past scans, not just future ones — that is the point, but there is no undo. Back up `openpantry.db` before a big cleanup session. The reorder report needs no attention afterward: forecast fits are keyed to each item's scan history, so a merged item refits by itself on the next report load.

MERGE BEFORE YOU TRUST A NEW ITEM'S PAR LEVEL

Duplicates are worth a look whenever an item you know is moving shows a surprisingly low order need — a second spelling is quietly holding the other half of its scans. The Menu Counter has its own separate de-duplicate tool for the order-form items in its own database.

TURNING SCANS INTO DECISIONS

Reports & the demand model

- **Order Now** — the reorder report. Computes a Par Level and how much to order per item. Its **Reorder reminders** line is grouped by unit, biggest request first, and the **Restock** box starts ticked on exactly those reminder rows that have an order request, so **Generate Email** and **Restock Now** act on what the page is asking you to order. Tick or untick rows to change that.
- **Days Not Scanned** — a panel at the foot of Order Now for days the pantry was open but nothing was scanned (volunteer absent, station down). Food still went out, so the demand model treats those days as **unobserved** rather than as zero demand, which would drag the averages down and hide reorder alerts. Enter a **Start** and **End** date to record a whole stretch at once (up to a year); both default to today, so a single missed day is one click. The list pages newest first, 30 days at a time. Don't list days the pantry was actually closed: nothing moving on a holiday is honest demand data.
- **Orders Listing** — every order and its items over a date range (delivery/event orders are tagged).
- **Item Usage** — per-item totals over a date range.
- **Daily Volume** — orders and scans per day.
- **Basket Size** — distribution of items per in-pantry trip over time.

- **Client Traffic** — when clients arrive, for planning volunteer shifts. One bar per half hour of the posted hours of operation, grouped by weekday; each bar is the average number of Menu Counter orders (from `picklist.db`) in that half hour on a typical open day. Hover a bar for the total and how many days were averaged. Orders placed outside the posted hours, such as stragglers just after closing, are counted in a tile but not charted. It defaults to the last 90 days.

UPDATE CLIENT TRAFFIC WHEN THE HOURS CHANGE

The report doesn't guess the pantry's schedule: the hours are listed in `TR_HOURS` at the top of `reports/traffic_report/traffic_report.php`, one line per weekday, with one [opens, closes] pair per session, on the half hour. When the posted hours change, edit that list and upload the file, or the chart keeps showing the old schedule.

- **Impact** — the report you hand a board member or a grant officer: pounds distributed, households and people reached, top items, and where the food came from, over a window you choose. The first time, it opens on the first of last month; after that it remembers the last **Start Date** you ran it with, and **Reset** forgets it. It is the only report that reads **both** databases — scans and orders from `openpantry.db`, counter requests and household sizes from `picklist.db` — and it keeps the two in separate sections rather than summing them, because a request a household typed and food that left the building are different events.

THE IMPACT REPORT'S TWO ASSUMPTIONS ARE YOURS TO SET

Packaged goods are counted, not weighed, so any pound figure covering them rests on an assumed **average pound per packaged item**; the meals-equivalent figure rests on an assumed **pounds per meal** (Feeding America uses 1.2). Both sit at the top of the report as editable inputs and are restated in its **Methodology & Caveats** card, so anyone reading the headline numbers can see what they depend on. Set them to whatever your funder expects before you print.

- **Where the Food Comes From** covers the pounds distributed in the chosen window, split donated vs. purchased by each item's lifetime **Bought** share from Restock. With no restock history at all it says so, rather than claiming everything was donated — so record restocks as purchased or donated if you want this card to mean something.
- **The fresh-produce chart groups varieties** into one bar per kind — Romaine and Iceberg both count as Lettuce, Sweet Potatoes as Potatoes. Hover a bar to see which items it includes. A name with no recognized kind keeps its own bar. The **Top Items Detail** table still lists individual items.

How Par Level is computed

For each item: **Par Level** = **Forecast(LeadTime)** + **SafetyStock**, where **SafetyStock** = $Z \times \sqrt{\text{Variance(LeadTime)}}$ and **Order need** = $\max(0, \text{Par Level} - \text{latest inventory count})$. Forecast and variance come from a quasi-Poisson model fitted to each item's weekly scan history, with a time trend and annual seasonality; dispersion inflates the safety stock so it reflects real volatility. Z defaults to 1.65 (~95%). Items with under ~2 months of history fall back to a trailing average and are marked with a °.

THE FORECAST CACHE IS DISPOSABLE

Fits are memoized in the `forecast_cache` table and rebuild on demand. If a report ever looks stale or wrong, that table is safe to delete — it will rebuild from the scan history.

Reorder alerts & email

Set a per-item lead-time alert and it shows as a banner on Order Now when projected days-of-stock drop below the threshold. Tick its **Email** box to also have it emailed. The cron job (`cron_reorder_alerts.php`) mails a digest of triggered, email-flagged items to the administrator address, at most once per ~20 hours per item.

AUTOMATED REMINDERS

The reorder cron job

Add a cron job (cPanel → Cron Jobs) that runs the mailer on your cadence, e.g. daily at 7am:

```
0 7 * * * /usr/local/bin/php
/home/you/public_html/openpantry/cron_reorder_alerts.php
```

CALL PHP BY ITS ABSOLUTE PATH

Use the full path to the PHP binary (e.g. `/usr/local/bin/php` on Namecheap-style cPanel hosts). A bare `.php` path can fail silently with “Permission denied” and no email ever goes out. Confirm with **Send Test Email** in Settings first.

THE ORDERING KIOSK

Administering the Menu Counter

- **Item admin** — add, remove, reorder (drag & drop), and toggle items; set category, name, sizes, and the **Family Factor** (multiplied by household size, capped at 5, rounded up) that decides how many units land in the pick queue.
- **Saving item changes** — edits stay on the page until **Save All Changes**, which asks for the administrator or supervisor password **once** when the save adds, removes, or edits an item's name, category, subtype, Family Factor, or Adults/Children setting, and says how many items each way. The **On** and **Unavailable** toggles and drag reordering save without it, so they can be flipped mid-shift. The server makes the same check itself against the items it holds, so if someone else added an item after your page loaded, a save that would delete it asks for the password too. Wrong passwords count toward the same lockout as the login screen.
- **Pick queue (Orders)** — the live back-of-house dashboard volunteers pull from; auto-refreshes every 5 seconds, and stops the pickers with a connection-lost window if it can't reach the server (see below).
- **Deduplicate** — merge duplicate item rows that crept in over time. This one is the Menu Counter's own order-form items; the item-name merge tool under Lookup Tables is a separate page for a separate database.
- **Reports** — item-usage reports with a chart; shoppers are anonymized as “Client N.”
- The Menu Counter shares the same login, allowed-IP, and allowed-hours gate as the rest of OpenPantry. Its order form shows exactly the items toggled **On** in Item admin — the Inventory page's Deliverable checkbox only affects the delivery menu, not the Menu Counter.

HOME DELIVERIES

Delivery paperwork & the AI upload

- **Print Menus (order forms)** — one page per pending client, with a checkbox per in-stock item. Each item shows its **default Qty / Weight in parentheses** — e.g. **(2 each)** or **(1.5 lb)** — computed from that client's household size with the same rules the packing list uses, so the two sheets always agree. A bold footer on every page asks volunteers to write changes next to the default amount only when the client requests them.
- **Packing & Delivery Lists** — per-client pick sheets for orders recorded this round. Count items show as **2 each**; produce delivered by weight shows as **1.5 lb**.
- **Pieces for by-weight produce** — when the item has an **Avg Wt** on the Inventory page, both sheets add the piece count that weight works out to, rounded to the nearest whole piece. The order form reads **(3 lb or 9 each)**; the packing list leads with the count, **9 each or 3 lb**, since packers fill the bag by counting. With no Avg Wt the weight stands alone.
- **AI upload** — completed forms are scanned to one PDF and read by vision AI in two independent passes; disagreements are flagged “verify against the paper” in the results table.

THE AI READS CHECKBOXES ONLY

The upload reader detects which boxes are marked — it does **not** read handwritten Qty / Weight corrections. When a volunteer writes a changed amount next to an item (per the footer instruction), apply that change by hand when packing; the packing list will otherwise show the standard computed amount.

WATCHING THE SERVER

The Uptime Monitor

The Uptime Monitor is a dashboard for whoever looks after the pantry's systems. Left open in a browser window, it checks the OpenPantry server every few seconds — whether or not anyone is scanning — sounds an alarm when it can't be reached, and keeps a timestamped log of every problem and recovery.

- **Opening it** — **Monitor Uptime** on the Settings page, or browse to </openpantry/monitor.php>. Either login works, administrator or supervisor. Unlike the stations it is **not** limited to the pantry's network, so it can run from home or an office.
- **How often it checks** — every 3 seconds during the Allowed Hours set in Settings, and once a minute outside them so an overnight monitor costs the server next to nothing. A failed check switches it straight back to every 3 seconds. With Allowed Hours turned off, it checks every 3 seconds all the time.
- **What a check covers** — the server itself, plus today's order counts from **both** databases (scan station and Menu Counter), so a database fault shows up too. One missed check is logged as a blip; two in a row is an outage.
- **The status card** — green **Online** while all is well; yellow **Server up — database problem** when a database can't be read; red and flashing during an outage, which also raises a red window you can hide (the card stays red) and says whether the fault is this computer's internet or the server. Grey **Signed out** means the login lapsed — that pauses the checks rather than counting as downtime, so sign in again. The browser tab's title shows the same state. Below the card: uptime

since opened, outage count and total downtime, the last good check with its response time, and orders today at each station.

- **Sounds** — the same three falling notes the stations play on an outage, repeated every 15 seconds while it lasts, and three rising notes on recovery. **Test sounds** plays both; **Sound on / off** silences them.
- **The event log** lives in the page only — refreshing or closing the tab starts a new one. **Copy log** copies it as text for an email or a ticket to the hosting company.

THREE THINGS THAT QUIETLY STOP IT

Click the page once after opening it: Chrome won't let a page play sounds until it has been clicked, and the page shows a reminder until you do. **Keep it in its own window**, and add the site under Chrome Settings → Performance → "Always keep these sites active" — otherwise Memory Saver can put a long-idle tab to sleep and the checks stop. And **clicking away** (the Settings button included) ends monitoring and its log.

WHERE YOU RUN IT DECIDES WHAT IT SEES

The monitor tests the connection **from the computer it's open on**. Run at the pantry, it also catches the pantry's own internet going down. Run from home, it watches the server only — it can't tell whether the pantry itself is online.

When a station loses the server

The scanning stations and the Menu Counter pick queue watch their own connection the same way. If a request gets no answer, a red **Connection lost** window stops the volunteer, refuses anything they try to save, and checks every few seconds until the server answers again. It then lifts itself and lists anything that was **not saved** or **may not have saved**, so it can be redone or checked. The window names one of three causes, and each asks something different of you:

- **No internet connection** — the pantry's own network: Wi-Fi, cabling, router, or the internet service. The server is fine.
- **The pantry server isn't responding** — the pantry's internet works but the OpenPantry host doesn't (a crash, the host's resource limits, maintenance). Restarting the router won't help; contact the hosting company, with the monitor's log if you have it.
- **The server refused this station** — the network gate turned it away. Either the pantry's public address changed (update **Secure Network Access** — a supervisor can do this), or it's outside **Allowed Hours**. The window lifts by itself as soon as the station is let back in.

Maintenance & troubleshooting

- **Backups** — back up `openpantry.db`, `menucounter/picklist.db`, and `encryption_key.php` together. The two databases hold your data; the key decrypts it. If you've set `OPENPANTRY_DB_DIR`, both databases live in that private folder instead of the app folders.
- **No email arriving?** Verify the admin email and SMTP in Settings, send a test, and check the cron PHP path (above). Without SMTP the app falls back to `PHP mail()`.
- **New barcode saved with a raw name?** The OpenAI step was skipped (bad/rate-limited key). Fix the key and edit the name under Lookup Tables.
- **Same item listed twice in a report?** Two spellings of one generic name. Merge them with **Consolidate Names** on Settings (`/openpantry/deduplicate/`), which also recombines the split scan history the par levels are built from.
- **“Access Denied” (or “The server refused this station”) for legitimate staff?** The public Wi-Fi IP changed or you're outside allowed hours. Update the allowed IP in Settings — or add the new line as one of the two additional addresses if the pantry now has more than one.
- **Stations showing “Connection lost”?** Read which of the three causes the window names (see “When a station loses the server”). Running the Uptime Monitor at the pantry gives you the timeline to hand the host.
- **End Order or Cancel refused?** If the message says the database was **busy**, another station was writing at that moment — tapping End again goes through. If it says **trying again will not help**, something is actually wrong; look at the host's error log. Either way the order is left exactly as it was — a failed close deducts nothing.
- **An order stuck open on a station that's gone?** Only the station that started an order can close it, so a laptop closed or a tablet carried off mid-order leaves it open, and stations in Assist mode keep re-joining it. Sign in as administrator or supervisor on any idle scanning station: the **Another station is scanning** card then offers **End** and **Cancel** for each open order. End deducts its items exactly as if its own station had; Cancel discards its scans. Both ask to confirm.
- **Locked out by the login throttle?** Wait out the timer, or use the 6-digit code emailed to the administrator address. A successful login resets the counter; 30 quiet minutes decay it on their own.
- **Report looks off?** Delete the `forecast_cache` table; it rebuilds from scans.

POST THESE AT EACH STATION

Opening checklists (for training)

These are the same checklists in the Volunteer Handbook. Print and post one at each station, and use them when training new volunteers.

CHECKOUT · LASER SCANNER OR CAMERA

Open-the-Station Checklist — Scanning Station

Work top to bottom. Tick each box as you go.

☐

Power on the Chromebook tablet and connect it to the pantry Wi-Fi (the station only works on the pantry network) if it is not already connected.

☐

Make sure the handheld barcode scanner is connected to the tablet; wait for its ready beep / steady LED.

☐

Power on the produce scale and confirm the scale strip reads **Scale ready**; see the setup below if it does not.

☐

Open the browser and go to the OpenPantry **Scan** page. It opens straight to the scanner — **no password** is needed, because the pantry network authorizes the station.

☐

Scan any item's barcode as a test — a “Last scan” line should appear. Then tap the red **×** **Cancel Order** so the test doesn't count.

☐

Tap once inside the barcode box so the cursor sits there (it glows green when focused).

NO WIRED SCANNER? USE THE CAMERA ON THE SAME PAGE

There is one **Scan** page for both ways of scanning. On a phone or any tablet without a handheld scanner, tap **Start Camera** in the *This Order* box and point the camera at the barcode — the page chirps once for each code it reads. **Stop Camera** puts it away. The camera needs permission the first time, and the page must be opened over **https**.

CHECKOUT · THE PRODUCE SCALE

Setting up the produce scale (once per tablet)

The **DYMO M25** is a USB scale. It plugs into the tablet and sends its readings to OpenPantry on its own — there is no keypad sequence to enter, no mode to select, and no unit to set, because the station converts whatever unit the scale displays into pounds. All it needs is power and, the first time on a given tablet, the browser's permission:

1	Stand the scale on a flat, dry surface with nothing on the platform.	Nothing on the platform
2	Plug its USB cable into the tablet.	Connected to the station
3	Press the scale's power key and let the display settle to 0 .	Zero / stable reading
4	On the Scan page, read the scale strip just above the barcode box.	Says what the scale is doing
5	If it says Scale not connected , tap  Connect Scale and pick the scale from the browser's list.	Once per tablet only
6	Confirm the strip reads  Scale ready .	Interfaced to OpenPantry

WHEN THE STRIP SAYS “SCALE READY”, YOU'RE SET

That line means the station is hearing the scale. You can then weigh produce in **either order** — scan the PLU and set the item on the scale, or weigh it first and scan the PLU when the station asks for it. You only ever tap **Connect Scale** once on a tablet: the browser remembers the scale and reconnects by itself every later shift.

THE SCALE SWITCHES ITSELF OFF

The M25 powers down after a quiet spell to save its batteries, and a scale that has shut off looks exactly like one nobody has touched. If the strip says  **Make sure scale is on.**, press the scale's power key to wake it — you do *not* have to redo the steps above. If the display is awake but not reading **0** with an empty platform, press its **Tare / Zero** key.

CUSTOMER ORDERING KIOSK

Open-the-Station Checklist — Menu Counter

The Menu Counter has two screens: the **customer order form** that shoppers tap, and the **pick queue** that volunteers pull from in the back.

Customer-facing tablet

- ☐ Power on the customer tablet and connect it to the pantry Wi-Fi.
- ☐ Open the browser to the OpenPantry **Menu Counter** order form. It opens directly — **no password** to enter.
- ☐ Confirm the page loads the item buttons grouped by category (Dairy, Dry Goods, Frozen, ...).
- ☐ Set the language selector back to English so the next shopper starts fresh.
- ☐ Stand the tablet in its holder facing the shopper; clean the screen.

Pick-queue tablet / screen (back of house)

- ☐ Open the **Menu Counter** → **Orders** (pick queue) page on the volunteer screen. It opens directly — **no password** needed.
- ☐ Confirm the queue auto-refreshes and the topbar shows “pending orders” and “items remaining”.
- ☐ Submit one test order from the customer tablet and confirm it appears in the queue, then Mark Complete to clear it.
- ☐ Make sure bags/bins and a pen are staged at the pick bench.

NO LOGIN ON THE PANTRY NETWORK

The Menu Counter order form and pick queue are secured by the pantry's network address, not a password, so volunteers never log in to use them. A password is only asked for on the administrator's **item-setup** screen — leave that to the person opening the pantry.